

AFTER ACTION REVIEW ON UNDP'S CORPORATE RESPONSE TO THE CONFLICT IN NORTHERN ETHIOPIA

SUMMARY REPORT



July 2025

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INTRODUCTION - AAR GOALS AND SCOPE

UNDP has conducted an After-Action Review (AAR) of its corporate response to the Northern Ethiopia crisis.

The AAR is a structured reflection that helps the organization to identify strengths and weaknesses and learn from the experience. The AAR covers the period of the **activation of the corporate support as an L3 crisis, from November 2020 to August 2024, including both the immediate response phase and the support to the implementation of the Peace Agreement.**

To examine UNDP's response to the crisis, **six primary aspects** have been identified:

- Overall clarity and timeliness of decision making for the response
- Use of evidence to inform decision making and programming
- Timeliness and effectiveness of programmatic response and the use of Corporate Funds
- Effectiveness of the operational response (Staffing capacity, SURGE, procurement, operations)
- Interagency coordination
- Effectiveness of crisis communication and resource mobilization

The present report is a summary of the findings, good practices and lessons identified and offers reflections on UNDP performance and recommendations to strengthen the corporate crisis preparedness and response.

SUMMARY OF FINDINGS, GOOD PRACTICES AND LESSONS LEARNED

FINDINGS

1. Overall Clarity and Timeliness of Decision Making for the Response

Overall, the northern Ethiopia crisis response **demonstrates UNDP's capacity for comprehensive organizational mobilization**, with multiple Bureaux, Offices, and systems working in coordination to provide financial, technical, operational and strategic support to the crisis response. The approach successfully leveraged UNDP's global presence and expertise while maintaining coherent strategic direction through its established governance mechanisms.

The northern Ethiopia crisis response also demonstrates **overall compliance with UNDP's Crisis Response SOPs**, particularly in core governance structures, funding and expert deployments.

Overall, **decisions at the corporate level were generally timely**, and contributed to UNDP's positioning as a leading actor in both the crisis response and recovery process, thanks to the technical and financial resources made available, that allowed the CO to take a leading role in assessment and in joint planning to provide a clear programmatic offer on recovery to the Government. These decisions proved strategically sound and consequential, mobilizing significant resources in TRAC3 funding and allocations from Funding Windows, while enabling assessments, deployment of SURGE expertise, authorizing business continuity measures when needed, and providing support for programmatic emergency and stabilization activities.

The fundamental strategic decision taken by the CO was to engage in Tigray (not originally a priority area), primarily due to the emerging conflict. UNDP demonstrated **strategic leadership** by positioning itself as the first development agency to engage the government with a recovery-focused approach rather than purely humanitarian response. Strategic engagement and communication with the Government maintained **crucial trust** during a challenging period.

The Ethiopia experience demonstrates the **strategic value of being a "first-mover"** in crisis response, even in uncertain political environments, provided that robust risk mitigation strategies and clear communication frameworks are in place to manage reputational challenges. Recognizing that "speed is of the essence" in crisis response, UNDP took a calculated risk approach **to maintain relevance in a rapidly evolving situation**; this required strong leadership support for risk-taking.

The **corporate response mechanism** functioned effectively, with appropriate Crisis Board decisions, a significant resource mobilization of USD 11.67 million in TRAC3 and Funding Window allocations, and the successful implementation of a "whole of UNDP" approach that coordinated multiple bureaus and expertise areas. The catalytic effect of corporate funding was particularly notable, with **initial UNDP investments leveraging approximately USD \$95 million in external resources**, demonstrating the strategic value of rapid corporate support in crisis contexts.

2. Use of Evidence to Inform Decision Making and Programming

UNDP's showed evidence-based decision making through its co-leadership of the Tigray early recovery assessment and the subsequent joint development of the Emergency Recovery Plan for Tigray, as well as the design of programmatic initiatives aimed at supporting the implementation

of the peace agreement, such as the Peace Support Programme/Facility (PSP/F) and the DDR programme. TRAC resources were allocated for the programmatic response based on assessment data in Tigray, and later for programmatic initiatives in Amhara and Afar as the conflict expanded. Evidence-based decision making was also critical when UNDP had to adapt its programming approach as circumstances evolved, and parts of the funding were allocated to sister UN Agencies with specific initiatives aimed at addressing identified humanitarian and resilience needs.

Assessment results guided resource allocation decisions across multiple sectors including governance, economic recovery, and social cohesion; recovery planning addressed the humanitarian, development, and peace nexus clearly identified as an essential strategic approach from the very beginning of the crisis.

Throughout the crisis, UNDP demonstrated **political acumen and a smart evaluation of the evolving dynamics in the country**, successfully operating in an extremely complex and volatile political environment while maintaining relevance and effectiveness.

3. Timeliness and Effectiveness of Programmatic Response

UNDP programmes are consistent with its crisis offering, its expertise and comparative advantage as an organization, and in line with needs identified during assessments. UNDP programmes implemented during the crisis have spanned social cohesion, restoring government functions, supporting the re-establishment of basic services and infrastructure damaged, restarting economic activities (especially for vulnerable groups, including women and youth), conflict prevention and peacebuilding, all of which are highly relevant to the situation in the regions affected by the conflict. The Ethiopia experience shows that leading with development solutions rather than purely humanitarian approaches can create unique positioning advantages. Future responses should consider maintaining this development lens while ensuring adequate coordination with humanitarian actors and managing stakeholder expectations about recovery interventions during conflict.

Gender equality integration varied across programmes, including gender considerations in assessments and programmes, and particularly in DDR and national dialogue initiatives; however, dedicated gender expertise was not included in SURGE Planning despite documented high levels of Sexual Gender Based Violence (SGBV) during the conflict. The proportion of resources dedicated to gender equality for *all* country programme activities reached required benchmarks in 2022 and partially in 2023 and 2024 (reaching the GEN2+GEN3=70% benchmark); crisis response and peace support activities have all been classified as GEN2, reaching the second benchmark (GEN2+GEN3 equal or superior to 70%) but not the first (GEN3 equal or superior to 15%).

The corporate support to programmes demonstrated strong pertinence across several dimensions, while timeliness varied, mostly due to the evolving situation in the country:

- **Financial Support:** UNDP's TRAC 3 funding proved highly relevant, providing resources for assessments, coordination and programming activities in all instances. After the first CB meeting, TRAC funds were deployed quickly, while they were released several months later in 2021 and 2022, given the challenging implementation context. Resources from Funding Windows were also highly relevant to the CO programmatic response to the crisis and support to the implementation of the peace agreement.

- **Technical Expertise (SURGE) Deployment:** The SURGE deployments were well-targeted to the Country Office's needs, responded to the required profiles and were deployed in multiple waves according with the shifts and evolution of the context. UNDP's ability to deploy expertise quickly was critical during the assessment phase and part of its successful engagement with the GoE. The quality of the technical assistance provided by surge advisors varied.
- **CB** coordinated corporate support effectively including technical and financial elements. **RBA** provided strategic leadership support, participated in coordination meetings, offered regional political and security analysis, and delivered programmatic oversight. **BERA** focused on external engagement by supporting donor sensitization, resource mobilization efforts, and communication needs in the politically sensitive environment, while **BMS** supported the CO in addressing critical operational challenges.

4. Effectiveness of the Operational Response

Several aspects of the operational support worked well: the involvement of operations teams in planning, execution, and reporting phases was particularly effective, as it ensured operational perspectives informed strategic decisions and operations teams could identify flexible solutions to strategic or programmatic challenges arising. The rapid deployment of UNVs provided crucial capacity augmentation when speed was essential, while the resource-sharing approach with the electoral support project exemplified creative problem-solving. The business continuity framework, including the devolution agreement with Kenya Country Office, provided a crucial safety net, even if in the end it was not necessary. Additionally, crisis special measures and accelerated procurement processes enabled faster response times.

Key challenges centered primarily around capacity constraints and external bottlenecks. The most significant internal challenge was the insufficient operational capacity for the speed required for crisis response. Limited **field presence** reduced UNDP's coordination capacity and ability to provide expected leadership in affected region, and external bottlenecks created some operational delays.

UNDP's **SURGE Deployment** mechanism proved valuable, with specialised expertise contributing to multiple critical products and helping position the organization effectively throughout the crisis. While surge deployments were generally positive, a need was identified for enhanced pre-deployment preparation, including cultural and gender sensitivity training, systematic end-of-mission reporting to capture lessons learned, and a mandatory evaluation of the SURGE performance. The experience also suggests that longer deployments may be more effective than shorter ones for building meaningful relationships and delivering substantial outputs. The CO has been able to **capitalise on specific high quality SURGE support provided**, in particular on the DDR programme, which was developed (and is currently led) by a SURGE Advisor and it has become the largest DDR programme in the world by caseload.

All SURGE expertise provided was relevant to the context; some observers have noted that given the extensive coordination role UNDP assumed in the assessments and later in the design of joint UN initiatives for peace support, a more extensive deployment of **coordination capacity** might have been beneficial. Similarly, a **Gender Specialist in the surge team** would have contributed to a more comprehensive integration of gender considerations in the recovery assessment and plan. **Gender equality in SURGE ToRs presented significant variations.**



5. Interagency Coordination

UNDP's coordination performance is mixed. On one side, **UNDP successfully coordinated the recovery assessment on Tigray, upon UNCT agreement, with GoE**. The CO also managed partnerships with agencies like UNFPA and IOM, however, its ambitious Peace Support Programme/Facility, initially intended as an interagency initiative, ultimately became a UNDP-only programme. Future joint initiatives should include stronger incentives for agency participation, clearer resource-sharing mechanisms, and interagency governance frameworks.

6. Effectiveness of Crisis Communication and Resource Mobilization

The CO maintained a very “respectful” and **careful approach in its communications** with the Government, which contributed to preserving a good relationship in a very sensitive political environment. The crisis was characterized by high level of misinformation and disinformation, with substantial reputational impact for UN agencies. UNDP position was not to engage with instances of misinformation or disinformation. The CO did not develop a Communication Strategy specific for the crisis, as would be required by the SOPs.

Virtually all external **resource mobilization** happened after the Cessation of Hostilities Agreement (CoHA); the higher proportion of external funding mobilised suggests a significant catalytic and leveraging effect of the corporate immediate support funds, which enabled the CO to engage and position during the crisis years and to act immediately when the peace agreement was signed, highlighting the importance of rapid resources mobilization at the beginning of a crisis, and the appropriateness of allocating internal resources to the emergency and peace support programmes. The decision to separate DDR from the PSP/F also proved strategically important for resource mobilization, as donors strongly engaged with the DDR program. The constant dialogue with donors, and the openness and transparency about challenges it faced, as well as intense resource mobilization with non-traditional donors have proven effective strategies for substantial mobilization of resources.

GOOD PRACTICES AND LESSONS LEARNED

Several good practices and lessons learned have been identified in the UNDP Ethiopia crisis response:

- Leadership in the initial stages of a crisis response (including in coordinating assessments) has contributed to UNDP positioning in all subsequent phases
- A proactive recovery-focused proposal to the Government rather than purely humanitarian response has also contributed to UNDP positioning
- There is strategic value in being a "first-mover" in crisis response, even in uncertain political environments, provided that robust risk mitigation strategies and clear communication frameworks are in place to manage reputational challenges.
- A risk-taking approach can be successful with robust communication and risk mitigation measures, *and* with the support of the organization's leadership
- Strategic engagement and careful communication with the Government contributes to maintaining crucial trust in politically challenging contexts
- Immediate corporate funding has a catalytic and leveraging effect on further resource mobilization, with initial UNDP investments leveraging approximately USD \$95 million in external resources, demonstrating the strategic value of rapid corporate support in crisis contexts.
- The involvement of operations teams in planning, execution, and reporting phases ensures that operational perspectives inform strategic decisions and operations teams can identify flexible solutions to strategic or programmatic challenges arising.
- Longer SURGE deployments may be more effective than shorter ones for building meaningful relationships and delivering substantial outputs on which the CO can later capitalize, as it was the case of the DDR deployment.
- Dedicated SURGE support on interagency coordination and joint planning can be necessary when UNDP takes a coordination role in interagency processes. Similarly, a Gender Specialist in the surge team can contribute to a more comprehensive integration of gender considerations in assessments, programme design and programme implementation.
- A constant dialogue with donors, the openness and transparency about challenges, and intense resource mobilization efforts including with non-traditional donors have proven effective strategies for substantial mobilization of resources.

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR UNDP CORPORATE SUPPORT

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR THE CRISIS BUREAU:

- **Strengthen calculated risk - taking at CO senior leadership level, jointly with the Regional Bureau:** Strengthen country office senior leadership capacity in risk management and political intelligence. Create space and provide backing for leaders who take calculated risks and offer dedicated political liaison support from headquarters for complex political environments. Advocate for taking necessary risks and support the development of robust risk management measures.
- **CO positioning:** Support country offices in immediate positioning to secure a ‘first-mover advantage.’ Ensure coordination and corporate backing from relevant bureaux within two weeks of a crisis onset. This should include political support at the senior management level, technical guidance on the programmatic offer, communications support for engaging key stakeholders, and any other assistance relevant to the crisis.
- **Enhance SOPs on gender equality:** Update SOPs to include mandatory requirements for dedicated gender expertise support (either deployed or remote) in Level 3 crises, and mandatory compliance with gender resources allocation (as per policy) before the release of additional CB funding or resources from Funding Windows; make gender competency requirements standard for all SURGE advisor terms of reference, not optional; add to the Crisis Board meeting a standing agenda point on the gender dimensions of the crisis and measures taken/to be taken to address them
- **Develop alternative crisis closure and review mechanisms in SOPs:** At the next review of the SOPs add streamlined closure processes for crisis responses that don't require full Crisis Board meetings when circumstances are straightforward.
- **Enhance pre- and post-deployment mechanisms for SURGE advisors:** Establish mandatory cultural and gender sensitivity training for all SURGE advisors and make end-of-mission evaluation of SURGE advisor performance mandatory and a precondition to permanence in the UNDP Roster. Moving forward, include a minimum requirement of 2 years of experience on gender equality for inclusion in the UNDP roster
- **SURGE:** Include a coordination expert and a gender expert as standard SURGE deployments at early stages, with a requirement for justification if not deployed (opt-out mechanism, rather than opt-in).
- **Security allocation:** During Crisis Board meetings, consider the option to dedicate funds to security arrangements, if needed.
- **TRAC3 funds release:** Ensure TRAC3 funding allocations are released within one month from the decision (pending the CO addressing any specific requirements before release).

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR BERA:

- **Communications and Resource Mobilization:** Support COs in developing a contextualized, dedicated Communication and Advocacy Strategy and a Resource Mobilization for the crisis, as determined in the Crisis SOPs. This is very relevant in sensitive/challenging political environments and with rampant disinformation/misinformation to maintain neutrality while addressing factual inaccuracies.

- **Strengthen relationships with International Financial Institutions (IFIs):** Develop systematic approaches for coordination with the World Bank and other IFIs during crisis response, including clear protocols for joint assessment processes, complementary programming frameworks, and engagement strategies for enhanced coordination.
- **Strengthen support to CO for donor engagement:** Provide support for CO management for donor relationships during politically sensitive crises, including guidance for balancing transparency requirements with political sensitivities.

RECOMMENDATION FOR BPPS:

- **Support to COs in crisis contexts:** Regularly participate in CB and CMST meetings and, in coordination and collaboration with the Crisis Bureau, proactively engage in technical support to COs in crisis response
- **Technical support to COs on development programming in crisis contexts:** Following the immediate crisis and in post-crisis situations, support COs to ensure from the start the linkage between crisis response and long-term development programming

RECOMMENDATION FOR BMS:

- Where relevant, provide comprehensive technical and operational support for strategic field presence establishment
- Support COs with creative solutions to address operational bottlenecks that delay or constrain implementation of programmatic activities

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR ETHIOPIA COUNTRY OFFICE

- **Develop comprehensive risk management plans during crises:** Establish systematic risk assessment frameworks that are updated regularly throughout the crisis and that include multiple risk categories including political, reputational, programmatic, financial/resource mobilization and operational risks. Include mapping stakeholder perceptions and developing contingency scenarios for different developments.
- **Strengthen communication strategy development:** Develop formal communication strategies immediately upon crisis declaration, as required by SOPs. This should include proactive messaging frameworks to counter misinformation, stakeholder engagement plans for different audiences (government, donors, civil society, communities, social media), and crisis communication protocols, and including tailored messaging for CO staff, and guidance on their professional and personal communications during crisis (especially relating to social media).
- **Strengthen gender integration from inception:** Ensure dedicated gender expertise is available throughout crisis response. Develop gender-transformative approaches from the outset by including substantial gender analysis in assessment and dedicated gender expertise, including specific and dedicated interventions addressing the needs of women and engage more with women's organizations as implementing partners beyond SGBV and protection issues. When designing programmes, ensure the inclusion of a minimum of 15% resources channeled through gender-transformative *outcomes*. Strengthen staff capacity on gender equality by disseminating UNDP guidance on gender equality programming, with the support of BPPS and the Crisis Bureau



- **Expand field presence:** Prioritise establishing appropriate field presence even in complex security environments, for stronger coordination and leadership, community engagement, and real-time programme adaptation. Consider alternative solutions for reduced financial implications (for example co-location with other UN Agencies)
- **Expand partnership base for programmatic coverage:** map civil society and community-based organizations (including women-led and women rights organizations, and youth-led organizations) in targeted areas as potential partner for implementation of programmatic activities
- **Prioritise expanding resource mobilization and programme coverage:** Develop explicit strategies for managing geographical coverage limitations and community expectations, including progressive expansion plans, communication strategies for non-covered areas, and coordination and partnerships with other actors to maximise overall coverage.
- **Enhance administrative processes and reporting:** Ensure rapid disbursement to partners for implementation of programmes, timely engagement with donors and timely reporting according to required standards.
- **Strengthen risk management capacity:** Encourage full implementation of the ERM policy, jointly with BMS, to support calculated risk-taking at CO level including use of risk assessment tools (e.g. HACT, SRM, programme criticality) and risk escalation Criteria.
- **Strengthen security resources availability:** When operating in high-risk environments, ensure sufficient availability of security resources for adequate management of evolving security dynamics.
- **Ensure compliance with crisis SOPs:** Including early development of communication and resource mobilization strategies.